



Working While Narcoleptic

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ABSTRACT

As a young person with narcolepsy, the author chronicles some of the challenges and hopes of being in the workforce. These journal entries center around the issues created by excessive daytime sleepiness and the experiences that drive the narrator to become self-employed.

KEYWORDS: narcolepsy, sleep disorder, employment, journal entries, alertness

Without warning, I became extremely sleepy. I was able to ignore it only for a few moments before I was compelled to do something. Instead of finishing dinner and excusing myself, I announced to my dad, the only other person still at the table, that I was feeling weird. “I’m *very* sleepy. I, I’m ... going to lie down, right here.”

“Nicole, don’t do that!” he calmly responded as I repositioned the chair beside me to turn the two chairs into an impromptu bed. “Put your plate up and go upstairs,” he continued.

It was too late. I was already asleep; he just couldn’t tell. To my dad, it looked like I merely decided to take a nap at the kitchen table instead of going upstairs to my bed. It must have been a five- to ten-minute nap. The whole time I could clearly hear him continuing to insist that I go upstairs. For some inexplicable reason, I was awake enough to hear him but not awake enough to follow his instructions or even acknowledge that I could hear them. Once the spell of sleep had lifted I was surprisingly alert, but I still went up to my room to lie in my bed. By then, all the sleepiness had drained away.

My dad had recently seen a *60 Minutes* special report on narcolepsy, which is why the next day he insisted that we talk to our doctor to see if our insurance would cover the sleep test and treatment. Weeks later, I was diagnosed at the age of 16.

I had complete control over the vulnerable moment of telling each of my grade school teachers about my diagnosis. The conversation's purpose was to let them know why my eyes might droop to a close during class. I was most vulnerable to falling asleep after lunch and after school. That first semester I needed to go to the nurse immediately after lunch to take another dose of Ritalin. When and if I forgot, the teacher would touch my sleeping head and quietly ask if I had remembered to visit the nurse. Sharing this part of my struggle with my teachers was comforting and reassuring on many levels. I discovered that my educators were genuinely interested in my condition and me. If my narcolepsy got in the way of performing in class or outside the classroom, I could request reasonable accommodations. However, aside from the friendly reminders to take my medicine, I never utilized accommodations while in grade school.

In college, very little changed about these private discussions. Talking to roommates, close friends, and professors about my narcolepsy was not only beneficial but also enjoyable. I savored the opportunity to introduce the people around me to something so unique and so intimate. It helped me build strong relationships with my educators and facilitated a life-long interest in the role of storytelling as well as grounded an unwavering trust in the virtues of teaching, research, and learning.

Despite having a disorder that threatened to make learning burdensome and reading untenable, I excelled as a full-time undergraduate student. My in-class performance was only boosted by out of class assignments like essays, test prep, and readings. If sleepiness affected one aspect of being a college student, like late-night cramming sessions, I made up for it in another realm of performance by absorbing everything during class with an alertness and attentiveness, buttressed by Adderall, that was unmatched by my peers. Sleepiness did not get in the way of having a fulfilling and enriching time in college and in grad school. Furthermore, there was no apparent reason to suspect that being an independent working adult would be any less fulfilling. This may have been naiveté or blind optimism. Either way, this honeymoon developmental phase of narcolepsy came to an end once I finished my master's degree.

As an independent adult, sharing my diagnosis is fraught with landmines. Should I tell this person and risk the demotion in terms of what they think of me, or will it strengthen our relationship? Will I be prompted to erroneously assure an employer that narcolepsy doesn't affect my work, or will I start to attribute unexplainable fumbles to the condition? Not to mention my fear that someone with power, like a manager, will find the diagnosis to be an elaborate excuse for laziness or otherwise dismiss the condition as being "all in my head." It turns out that there is no clear answer to the question: To what extent should the people around me know about my sleep disorder?

Aside from issues of disclosure, there is an even more important aspect of working that must be addressed. Living independently means that I am

completely responsible for paying my bills and keeping a roof over my head. This self-sufficiency accompanies an ever-present fear that if my symptoms appear to employers or coworkers, my ability to provide for myself can disappear, suddenly. I should clarify that this is not merely a fear, but it has happened to me at least once and I may always be haunted by the prospect of it happening again.

Throughout most of my struggle with narcolepsy, I managed my EDS (excessive daytime sleepiness) through a delicate balance of medication, good sleep hygiene, and vigilant self-awareness. Nevertheless, there will always be days when I don't unexpectedly fall asleep and days when a fog of sleepiness touches everything. Like many other people with narcolepsy, I am on a journey to find a place in this world where I can create value despite inevitable struggles with sleep and sleepiness. These journal entries are milestones during this tumultuous journey.



AUGUST 25, 2005

As I neared the Louisiana/Texas border it became apparent that singing might not keep me awake and alert for the next three hours needed to reach my final destination, Houston.

*Nature had her way with you.
Extensions of each other
Born to one another
Born to one another
In love.*

"Extensions," sung by jazz vocalist Rachelle Farrell, is one of the songs in my repertoire for singing while behind the wheel. Singing is a fairly full-proof method of keeping sleep at bay. The trick is remembering to do it. I know several of the songs from her debut album *First Instrument*, most of which are familiar jazz standards utterly transformed by Rachelle's multi-octave range and distinctive style.

*Eyes of Fire
Wings of Laughter,
Love did you know?
Nature had her way with you.*

I pulled into a one-story motel with a full parking lot, but to my surprise, there was a vacant room for me. This was the end of a six-hour, bumper-

to-bumper, pre-Hurricane Katrina exodus west. It usually takes about four hours to reach the Texas border from New Orleans, but I could not avoid the crawl of the packed freeway. This was the longest drive I had ever made alone. Cautiously, I filled with pride as I called to let my mom and dad know that I was stopping for the night. Today my horizons broadened significantly. For as long as I could remember, long drives were left up to my more alert friends and family members, just to be safe. And yet, I drove all this way without stopping and without getting sleepy.

I am an I-10 baby because interstate trips up and down this southern freeway punctuated my childhood and youth. One parent would drive the whole six-hour trip without needing to stop for anything but gas and food. This is something that I thought could not be done by someone with my condition.



SEPTEMBER 5, 2005

A Houston job offer came before my job hunt officially commenced. I will be working with the ambitious couple Richard and Rachelle Moore, directors of a nonprofit arts organization that they founded. They knew me before I went off to college in Atlanta.

Naomi, my sister who is three years younger than I am, met the Moores first. Richard was helping to judge an art contest that Naomi had entered. As a result, my sisters and I were invited to work on a mosaic project with the Moores that year, and it turned out to be easy and fun work. Fast forward to post-Katrina, past my participation in other mosaic mural projects during my college summer breaks in Houston, and past my dinner with Richard and Rachelle's during their visit to Atlanta. My long-standing relationship with the Moores and a bold confidence to rise despite the setbacks of Hurricane Katrina seemed to be the reason I was offered the job as project coordinator.



JANUARY 20, 2006

It is over! All over! I finally got my dosage increased and now I should be more than barely functionally awake. Now I should once again be able to read books at any time of the day or night and write endlessly. Hopefully, I will even be able to think straight during the day. Before this day ends and I start to take ten more grams of Adderall daily, I want to reflect on how this happened.

Ever since my diagnosis, I have taken medication daily to ensure alertness, but I can still become sleepy while on these stimulants. They are prescribed to narcoleptics like me to keep us awake enough to allow us to do necessary

activities like driving, reading, writing, and paying attention during meetings. Thankfully, I never struggled with insomnia or catalepsy, which would have called for a complex cocktail of medication. The only symptom that needs treatment is my EDS.

While in college and in graduate school, I saw an array of different doctors once or twice and then never again. Many of these doctors expressed a mixture of skepticism and shock at the high dosage of stimulants that such a petite girl required to stay awake. The hesitancy and alarm they expressed instilled a mild distrust of and ongoing wariness toward such stimulants. The regular need for work-ups to make sure the medication wasn't damaging my kidneys was no assurance either. The summer following my last semester in graduate school heralded a season in which I had less reading and writing to do, so I asked that my dosage of Adderall be lowered. This should have only lasted the three summer months. Later, when my responsibilities increased I would just see a neurologist to get my dosage adjusted and I would be back to normal. August did not go as planned; nothing went as planned. Hurricane Katrina, outgrowing my mother's health insurance, working during the day, not having a neurologist, and the ongoing effort to replace so many things that I lost after Hurricane Katrina all made seeing a doctor difficult for several months. I was undermedicated for far too long.

Now that my medication has been adjusted, I have to wonder about the future. What will I do about my need for medication once the Cobra health insurance runs out? What can I do? Will I still be able to get medication without insurance? Will I still be able to work and drive without medication? What will my life look like when I don't have health insurance?



MARCH 2, 2006

Before starting to work with the Moores, I consulted my friend, Ann, who graduated with a degree in Human Resources and was currently working in HR. In addition to the hours of reading internet posts on the subject, I sought her help in figuring out how to deal with the problem of working while narcoleptic. It turns out that the Americans with Disabilities Act applies only to employers with more than 15 employees, meaning that I needed to tread lightly at this tiny nonprofit. As a result of our conversation and hours of reading personal experiences and professional resources, I came up with a plan. I would tell the Moores about my narcolepsy, give them plenty of information, and then just hope for the best.

I scheduled a time when I would give the Moores all the information I had on narcolepsy and work. We also talked about my symptoms and my treatment. I covered all the usual things that I go over. Ever since I was

diagnosed, I have warned superiors several times a year, but the stakes were always much lower because they were all typical teenager part-time jobs to help afford trips to the mall. This was the first time I had a job where I was going to need to be awake from nine to five but that I didn't expect my sleep disorder to interfere with my performance. However, because this was my first experience with this type of work schedule, I did not know what to expect.

As it turns out, Richard also did not know how he would react when he came face to face with my excessive daytime sleepiness. Unfortunately, a diagnosis, medication, and a full disclosure all do not change the reality that falling asleep while working can be grounds to be fired.

The night before falling asleep on the job, I did not get a full night's sleep; hence, I was very aware of my heightened vulnerability to sleep attacks. I have never fallen asleep while standing, which is why my plan was to spend the entire day on my feet in the studio working on a mosaic mural that needed to be finished soon. This kept sleep so much at bay that by the afternoon I had forgotten about the imminent danger of my sleep-deprived predicament: extremely high sleep latency. My ultimate demise occurred in the early afternoon when I finally sat down to check my email.

"Nicole!" I awoke to Richard walking past the door and calling my name. Hearing my name mysteriously blows away the clouds of sleepiness. Alertness surfaced quickly, but I was slow to discover the true damage created by this particular sleep attack. Richard was on his way to answer the doorbell, which, according to him, had been ringing for some time. It was just a delivery. On the way back to his office, he stopped at my door to convey his disappointment and to make sure I knew that a few minutes earlier he was the one stuck outside helplessly ringing and ringing. He thought that I was in the back still working on the mosaic and unable to hear the bell. When he called my name, he had just discovered that the whole time I had been sound asleep in front of my computer, a few feet away from the door.

Immediately, I went back to work on the mosaic, hoping for the best. There were no questions about my narcolepsy and no lectures about laziness. There was only an abundance of frosty silence. As the day progressed, he did not address it or ask about it, and for that I was thankful. I did not know what to say, so I said nothing. That is all I remember about this heartbreaking day.

The next day I arrived at the downtown office greeted by a box of my belongings. Rachelle offered no explanation, no expression of appreciation, and no conversation, only "Your services are no longer needed."

After insisting that there were things in the desk that still needed to be retrieved, I was allowed to enter "my" office. Rachelle stood over me and scrutinized each piece of paper to which I laid claim. Richard was around and interacted with Rachelle that morning right in front of me. My suspicions

were correct. In fact, it was now obvious that Richard could no longer even look at me. I could not believe this! Here is the man who, when offering the job of project coordinator, looked me in the eyes and said, to my utter surprise, “In truth, I’m hoping that one day *you* will be running this organization.”

Suddenly, after falling asleep once, I was now a nonperson to him; someone he could neither acknowledge nor greet. None of the conversations about my narcolepsy, and the folder full of information on the disorder and its implications on working, mattered anymore. I’m not sure if it ever mattered.

Not sure what I did that morning after being fired. I might have driven home and spent the day in bed crying, or perhaps I went home and finally opened all of those unopened paychecks because I was still living off of the Katrina flood insurance payout. Then again, maybe I went for a run on the bayou. I might have done all of the above or none of the above. Not only did someone that knew about my excessive daytime sleepiness use these symptoms as grounds to fire me, but the job was neither financially or personally fulfilling. These factors should make it easier to deal with the trauma, but, in reality, they only deepen psychological wounds, some of which were hidden until now. I didn’t want to be there; I wanted a life that was flooded when the levees broke.

How deep is this laceration? Did it only pierce my pride or did it touch any vital parts like my ego, my self-confidence, my ability to trust others, or my determination to overcome the difficulties of narcolepsy? Will such a wound ever heal completely? This is one of those memories that will be reluctantly preserved. Subsequent memories of working on mosaics, the image of Richard, or the sight of one of these murals seem to conjure the most persistent negative emotions I’ve ever experienced. I want this intimate torture to end.

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MARCH 23, 2006

Up till now, I still was not able to overcome the need to repress unsavory emotions. I did not direct my negative emotions toward anything in particular. Instead, I tacitly nurtured an acidic stew of emotions that contained, among other things, pieces of memories and a bunch of questions. I am not able to condemn Richard and Rachelle although they are contemptibly flawed individuals. Being fired was no license to hate anything, especially not my employer or my narcolepsy.

Perhaps, if my experience and my trauma could be put inside a larger narrative, it would go a long way in helping me to make sense of what happened and allow me to move on to something better. This is why I

contacted the girl that I was hired to replace. Since I now had a surplus of time on my hands, I found her on Facebook and made arrangements to meet in person. We quickly bonded over what a debacle working with this arts organization had been. The Moores had also fired her and the secretary on the same day and without warning. I also discovered that Rachelle had been working without pay in order to pay me, even though she was my direct supervisor. It became clear that their organization was on life support. This actually made me a little happier to be leaving the Moores, but this new context did not uproot the melancholy that had already taken hold.

While this helped make sense of some aspects of the drama, none of this healed the real wounds. Is it the narcolepsy that they couldn't deal with or is there something fundamentally wrong with me? I used to be able to tell the difference, but now it is all a blur.



APRIL 14, 2006

This entry is yet another attempt to look at my life via the comfortable distance of intellectual questions—am I more emotionally scarred by narcolepsy than disabled by it?

The last few days I've had to try really hard to reassure myself that despite the failed attempt at getting into a Ph.D program, despite being fired from a job I hated, and despite not having a decipherable back-up plan, I am still a valuable individual with a lot to offer. Yet the only plan that I can now devise must include a job and an employer. These are the very things that epitomize the sum of my most prevalent source of insecurity: not being awake when it counts, not being alert when it matters the most, falling asleep at an inappropriate time and place, messing up my speech and sounding stupid and confused, being sleepy and despondent, being struck with fatigue, and, of course, the unintentional and unexplainable early day yawn. Any of which can lead toward the irreparable negative character judgments that are immune to the accommodations the Americans with Disabilities Act provides. Nothing can protect me from the opinions people have about daytime sleepiness; nothing can stop it from happening again.

Despite all the internal will I've mustered, I can't—or should I say that, I *couldn't*—convince myself that I am still an exceptional individual and that I can overcome this disorder. For the first time in my life, I am seriously starting to doubt whether I can have a fulfilling full-time job despite my narcolepsy. This paralyzing insecurity is the only thing of which I am sure. It is like gravity. Everything else is pulled by it. This diffidence has been the basis of many of my life's major decisions.

Fear and insecurity often accompanies my climb to consciousness and lingers long after a sleep attack. I'm reminded of a narcoleptic in Dement's book, *The Promise of Sleep*, who was a waitress until she collapsed with a tray of drinks in her hand at a cocktail party surrounded by guests. The inability to heal her self-esteem was far more debilitating than the physical injuries she sustained. It's as if falling in public facilitated opportunities for other declines. Self-esteem, self-confidence, assuredness, comfort, hope, happiness, and self-determination are all things that unsuspecting narcoleptics may take with them when engulfed by sleep—sometimes we awake seconds, minutes, or hours later with our precious passenger still buckled in safely, but other times we return without something.

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MARCH 28, 2007

These days it is too easy to talk myself out of writing, journaling, working out, cooking, cleaning, or working. I usually attribute such lackadaisical moments to my level of sleepiness, saying I can't focus because of my sleepiness or my sleep patterns, or because of the time of day, and on and on.

I have recently come to the realization that the sleepiness from narcolepsy will get in the way of everything I try to do, little and big. While being medicated, I doubt I will ever be significantly handicapped in everyday activities, yet there does not seem to be a part of my life not touched by this neurological condition. This is still a fairly new epiphany. I am an overachiever in many ways, so I have to try and reconcile this contradiction. These things, writing, reasoning, typing, and being clear-headed, will always pose a challenge because of an ever-present potential for sleepiness.

There is no respite in the fact that I must try to overcome and compensate for my nonalertness only to have to fight the same battle again and again. Will I always want to take on narcolepsy, sleepiness, and its fallout? What do I get for putting up a fight? Slowly I'm coming to see why narcoleptics so easily disappoint employers and managers. Although we are productive and ambitious creatures, our narcolepsy overruns our most basic virtues as it drowns us in an impenetrable lethargy. This is the reason I want to be self-employed: I will only disappoint myself and hopefully be able to spare employers and clients such disappointments.

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MARCH 15, 2010

The last time I fell asleep at my sister's place was while facing a floor to ceiling mirror. Between microsleeps, I scrutinized the narrowness of my almond-shaped eyes for signs of a looming sleep attack. What do I look like when I

am fighting off sleep? I couldn't see the sleepiness on my face. I also don't think my nine-year-old nephew saw it, even though we were playing checkers. I sensed the tide rising and slowly covering a damp alertness. Was I going to get sleepier or would I wake up? For a few moments, I fought off the sleep attack hoping that talking and playing checkers would somehow awaken me. Alas, narcolepsy made keeping my eyes open untenable. I apologetically called off the game and groggily moved toward a secluded chair.

Today, I was substituting at my favorite middle school. The kids seemed to be pretty tame today, but the assignment that the teacher left for them was a bit too tame. As they filed into the class, I handed each student a packet of science readings and questions. Straightaway, I introduced myself. The only instructions they needed were to work quietly.

The highlight of the day was an early interception that could have sent two kids to the principal's office. I talked with a girl, one-on-one, outside the classroom right after the first disruptive outburst.

With pleading eyes she exclaimed, "He's over there talking about me!"

This petite black 7th grader was about to explode with frustration. The girl seemed determined to let the boy sitting in front provoke her into violence. The boy persisted in bothering her because he found her animated response amusing. She proved very willing to rise to the occasion, always including a threat of physical retaliation.

After talking with her twice and with the young man once, they succeeded in ignoring each other and getting their classwork done. That was during 2nd period, and there was still a whole day to look forward to. Most days it is a welcomed mystery as to whether the day would bring well-behaved students or those needing a lot of redirection and attention.

During the 4th period, after lunch, it happened. Mid-day tends to make me quite vulnerable, but each day substituting is so unpredictable that I could have never anticipated what happened next.

I was trapped. Unable to succumb to true sleep to end the limbo, and yet also unable to find the internal commands needed to tell my body to, "stand-up," "stretch," "walk around the room," "make small talk," "just do something." Just don't fall! Not now! Not while working!

This class had the one girl in the entire 7th grade that was so unattuned to body language and social cues that I am left to wonder if she would have reacted to my state if it were observable. Amid this haze, she came up to the desk and asked what to do next, now that she was finished working. She handed me her packet and I flipped through the pages to discover she overlooked working on a whole page. Pointing this out, I handed the papers back. None of this pulled me out of the twilight state. The exact same exchange had already occurred with at least six other students during that period and with at least twenty other students that day. This interaction was

able to occur exactly because it was so practiced and unremarkable. It did not require enough thinking to awaken me.

How did I look behind the teacher's desk? Should I be thankful that my almond-shaped eyes either hid what was going on or made sleepy eyes harder to detect? There were no suspicious looks nor did any student look my way and then quickly whisper something to their neighbor before stealing another glance. This time, my face must have veiled the reality that for about five minutes I was half-asleep while substituting.

Sadly, this is what made me consider going into K-12 education. More specifically, Maya, a friend and classmate in college told me about her high school teacher who had narcolepsy and how he would sometimes just fall asleep in class. Many years ago this planted a curiosity and a hope that perhaps there was something special about working in K-12 education.

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MAY 17, 2010

My mom is a rare specimen in the information age because the practice of dedicating one's life to a single employer in exchange for a satisfying retirement ended way before 1998, the year of her retirement. During her entire career, she worked for Amoco—the multinational oil and chemical company—until it merged with BP. At this point, she was able to retire comfortably and pay for my private liberal arts college tuition out of pocket. I would describe her as a mulatto Creole, but she would just call herself black. My dad's blackness is less complicated and less diluted. They were both one of nine children. Whereas my mom was a faithful employee, my dad was self-employed for most of his life.

As I grew from a young girl that admired Barbie dolls into teenager that admired Malcolm X, my parents' occupations did not change at all. Their very different forms of employment battled for my adoration as the ideal way to make a living. I often wondered: Did I want to be an employee or a self-employed person when I grew up? Both situations had notable perks. Our health insurance and dental coverage came from my mom's employer, and her income supported our regular expenses and trips to the mall. When he was in town, my dad was able to welcome us home after school and he had plenty of time to make sure dinner was ready for the family each evening.

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OCTOBER 29, 2010

Today it is official: I'm a business owner.

I forgot to take my medicine! Worse yet, it took way too long for me to realize my oversight. Such days tend to plague me with an ongoing hunger. It is the pattern of excessive snacking that gives me pause and prompts me to search my visual and tactile memory for the moment I took my medicine in the morning.

This part of starting a business is pretty boring. It is so boring that I don't mind falling asleep in public here. There was no head bobbing, just a heaviness lying right below my skin. This heaviness pulls my eyes into little slits and then starts to take over with the sullen certitude of colorful leaves not ready to fall. My attention narrows sharply to only take in details and forsake the larger environment. My eyes are open, but just enough to not betray that I am en route to slumber.

"Are you still waiting to talk to Mrs. Cook?" says the clerk.

I jump up onto my feet. It was a brisk seamless transition into regular alertness. Once in her chair, a different piece of sleep falls upon me. When I introduce my questions, there is no rambling. My eye contact is strong. I like what I see. This woman is interesting. She moves with the gracefulness of a petite beauty pageant winning girl. I think she has a perm. She is round, but not excessively corpulent. I like watching her do my paperwork because although her body is no work of art, her movements do a kind of dance for me or perhaps the dance is for her. There is no vibrato, no crescendo, just a nice soft melody. The piece of sleep that soothes and assuages befalls me here. The sugary coating of sleep persuades sleepers to delay waking, and today it is sprinkled upon everything I observe.

Next, I have to go back to the courthouse to file my DBA, even though I was just there. The clerk did not give me any specifics as to where I need to go once I return to the building.

"It should say 'Assumed names' on the directory," she explained.

The weightiness that closed my eyes in the tax office is still present. Perhaps a McDonalds iced coffee would help. Oh yeah, plus doughnuts would be nice with that. This pulls at me even when I am about to get out of my car at the courthouse. It wins. The GPS says that a McDonalds is less than a mile away and so is a doughnut place. Then I head back to the courthouse, all sugared up. This time I head to a nook that I've never seen before. I join the line of people filing DBAs and couples getting marriage licenses. No smiles beyond the ones offered when they first entered the room. No one knows how long the wait will be.

I stand in front of a young man filling a DBA and behind an East Asian couple. The woman has a nice denim Coach purse and straight shiny hair that stops just past her shoulders. Her face never comes into view, but her partner never stops looking around. He is a modest, short man who is starting to bald. They were about my age. One moment they are in front of me and

the next moment they have a marriage certificate. They raise their right hands and repeat after the civil servant. Meanwhile, three doe-eyed couples join the line. We each arrived with predictable hopes and pregnant plans of what to do with our DBAs or marriage licenses. This is a room full of dreamers.



OCTOBER 20, 2012

Today, I drive to Waco, Texas to buy inventory for my online store. The goal is to get there early to wait in line to get first pick. Because it is a 3.5-hour drive, if I leave around 5:10 a.m., when my daily alarm clock goes off, I should make good time. It has been nearly a half a year since I've made one of these trips to buy inventory. Missing my departure goal was an overlooked omen on how the trip would unfold.

First, I listened to a Spanish audio book through my car's speakers. I would repeat basic Spanish words and phrases. I hoped this would work just as well as singing to myself and would keep sleep at bay during what was turning out to be a very dark, foggy drive. About thirty minutes away from home, I felt that familiar nibble at awareness narrowing my field of vision. Right off the highway, I found a place to nap. Pulling into an Olive Garden parking lot made sense because in the neighboring lot there was a truck being unloaded in the back. Intentionally picking a spot that was in view of the early morning worker, I fumbled through my belongings in the passenger seat to retrieve my oversized sunglasses. Then, I let sleep have its way with me. No alarm clock was set since I was confident that this was going to be a quickie.

The clarity that greets awaking is sometimes a bit of a jolt. If I'm in the middle of confronting numerous problems or challenges, I especially look forward to awakening. This is because each nap carries the chance that I'll awake to a Zen flavored shot of sobriety and rise with a solution or a plan in hand. This time I was greeted by a shot of energy, reassuring me that I was ready to return to the flat Texas highway.

Spanish was droning on when it happened again. Only a half-hour had passed since the last stop. This time dawn was on the horizon. Initially, when my alertness started to turn into mush, anxiety and disbelief shook the sleepiness off me.

This can't be happening again, already!

Usually, I need only one nap on long drives like this and only on the afternoon trip home. Spanish was obviously not working. I did not have enough time to take all these naps and still get to Waco early. After switching to a recently released novel, which was much more interesting than reviewing Spanish, the threat of a microsleep returned. I stopped in the parking lot of a

fast food restaurant, not facing the building. Beside an oversized pick-up truck, I put on my sunglasses and checked the time. Since I usually wake up before an alarm goes off, I decided once again not to set an alarm. I was confident that a little five-minute nap was all my body would permit.

The sun was up when I awoke, nearly an hour later. I overslept! There was only a tiny chance that I could still reach Waco in time, so it was now apparent that turning around and heading all the way back home was a real option because I still had two hours of driving. These two naps make me wonder if something interfered with me sleeping soundly through the previous night.

I am not sure which is more discomfiting: the fact that I remember chastising myself for taking a total of three naps during the drive to Waco or the fact that I do not remember any of the details of this third nap. This is the part of sleep that resembles a magic eraser. It is most likely to drop in for a visit after short naps to erase what it pleases. This was supposed to just be a three-hour drive, but I took three naps. I couldn't believe it. How am I going to get home at this rate?

My car pulled into the parking lot just as the line of early birds finished entering the convention center. I hesitate to say I was late, but I definitely was not early and it cost me dearly. It was still a profitable trip. After the sale and against my better judgment, I had a real meal for lunch, a 6-inch veggie sandwich from Subway.

To my complete astonishment, there were no naps during the drive home. Perhaps I was excited about the successful trip, or perhaps a good novel is just what I needed to keep me completely awake the whole trip. Narcolepsy never fails to surprise even me.

Because I am not cataleptic, and therefore not prone to sudden sleep attacks, I've been without any sleep-related accidents. This was a very atypical trip and it is even a bit disturbing. It is a bit embarrassing to acknowledge the way such roadside naps seem completely normal to me. Some people will nap during eight-hour drives, and some people nap during two-hour drives, today I discovered that I just happen to be a part of the latter group.

Some diagnosed and treated narcoleptics, like me, are safer and more cautious behind the wheel than the average person is because of our hyper-awareness of the many forms of sleepiness. The person that falls asleep behind the wheel usually spends a lot of time ignoring the signs of sleepiness. I am aware of even subtle turns toward repose, and I am equipped with a number of ways to address them. For now, I am quite content to deal with unexpected calls to nap in the solitude of my quiet silver Corolla and in the solitude of self-employment.